



GUNSHY FIX · PAYSON, UTAH

FREE GUNSHY FIX TRAINING GUIDE

5 Gun Introduction Mistakes That Can Create a Gun-Shy Dog

A Practical Guide From Bird Dog Trainer Tyce Erickson

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BEFORE YOU START

Before You Introduce Your Dog to Gunfire

Most hunters do not intentionally create a gun-shy dog.

Usually, they are excited.

They have a new puppy or young hunting dog. The dog is retrieving well, showing bird drive, and they are ready to take the next step.

So they introduce a gun.

Sometimes everything goes fine.

Other times, that first experience creates a problem that can take weeks or months to work through.

One of the biggest things I wish more hunters understood is this:

TYCE'S RULE

You do not need to test a dog to find out whether it is gun shy.

A gradual introduction gives the dog a much better opportunity to build a positive relationship with gunfire from the beginning.

Here are five mistakes I see owners make—and what I would do instead.



The dog is retrieving well, showing bird drive.
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Mistake #1

Testing the Dog With a Gunshot

This is probably the most common mistake I see.

Someone has a young dog and wants to know whether it is gun shy.

So they take the dog outside, fire a gun, and watch what happens.

The problem is that the test itself can create the issue.

The owner may think:

“If the dog is okay with it, great. If not, we’ll know.”

But that first shot may be much louder or closer than the dog is ready for.

The dog is not learning that gunfire is positive.

It is simply being surprised by a loud noise.

What I Do Instead

I want something positive happening **before the gun is ever introduced**.

For a hunting dog, that may be:

- Birds
- Retrieving
- Chasing
- Prey drive
- Play
- Movement

Once the dog is highly engaged and having a good time, gunfire can be introduced gradually at a distance.

The goal is not to see what the dog can tolerate.

The goal is to build confidence.

TYCE’S RULE

Never use gunfire to test whether a dog is gun shy.

Mistake #2

Starting Too Close or Too Loud

There is no prize for getting a puppy comfortable with a close shotgun blast as quickly as possible.

When I first introduce live gunfire, I want the shooter far enough away that the shot is **barely noticeable to the dog**.

That distance will not be the same for every dog.

One puppy might be comfortable at a certain distance while another needs much more space.

The dog determines the starting point.

What I Look For

If the dog is working around birds or retrieving, I want it to continue doing exactly what it was doing before the shot.

Is it still:

- Chasing?
- Retrieving?
- Hunting?
- Showing bird interest?
- Moving with the same energy?

If yes, we may be able to continue gradually.

If the dog stops and begins focusing on the shot, we have probably started too close.

What I Do Instead

Start farther away than you think you need to.

You can always move closer later.

It is much easier to build confidence gradually than to repair a bad first experience.



Mistake #3

Assuming the Dog Is Fine Because It Didn't Run Away

A gun-shy dog does not always run back to the truck.

Some dogs do.

Others simply shut down.

This is where owners sometimes miss the early signs of a problem.

The dog may stay right beside them, so they assume everything is okay.

But before the shot, the dog was ranging through the field, hunting, retrieving, or chasing birds.

After the shot, the dog begins walking directly beside the owner.

That is a change.



The question is not simply whether the dog ran away. Did the dog's normal demeanor change?

Signs I Watch For

A dog may be showing concern around gunfire if it:

- Stops ranging out
- Stops hunting
- Stops retrieving
- Loses bird interest
- Walks behind or beside the handler
- Becomes unusually quiet
- Lowers its energy
- Becomes clingy
- Focuses on the gun instead of the activity
- Runs back toward the truck

The question I ask is not simply:

“Did the dog run away?”

I ask:

“Did the dog's normal demeanor change?”

TYCE'S RULE

The goal is a dog that hears gunfire and keeps being itself.

Mistake #4

Moving Forward Because of the Calendar Instead of the Dog

Owners like schedules.

The dog does not care about your schedule.

There is no rule that says:

- Move the gun closer after three days.
- Increase the volume after five repetitions.
- The puppy should be ready by next weekend.
- The dog has to be ready before hunting season.

The dog determines when you progress.

What I Do Instead

Watch the dog's demeanor.

If the dog stays happy, driven, and engaged, you can gradually move forward.

If the dog:

- Stops retrieving
 - Stops hunting
 - Becomes concerned about the sound
 - Loses energy
 - Comes back toward the handler
 - Stops acting normally
- then you back up.

That may mean moving the gun farther away.

It may mean returning to an earlier sound level.

It may mean taking live gunfire out of the training temporarily.

The Important Part

TYCE'S RULE

Progress is based on comfort, not time.

Trying to rush because hunting season is coming can turn a small issue into a problem that takes months to repair.

Mistake #5

Trying to Fix Fear With More Gunfire

This is one of the biggest mistakes I see after a problem has already started.

The dog reacts badly to gunfire.

The owner thinks:

“He just needs to hear more of it.”

So they:

- Keep taking the dog hunting
- Shoot around the dog repeatedly
- Take the dog near a shooting range
- Tie the dog somewhere while people shoot
- Play loud gunfire recordings
- Continue increasing the sound

They may call that desensitization.

That is not how I approach desensitization.

If the dog is already frightened, starting with an intense sound can reinforce the fear instead of reducing it.

What I Do Instead

Back up.

Start at a level where the dog can remain comfortable.

Keep something positive going.

Then build gradually.

With live gunfire, that may mean going back to birds or retrieving and putting the shooter much farther away.

For dogs that already have a strong negative association with gunfire, I may back away from live shooting and use a controlled sound progression first.

TYCE'S RULE

If the dog is already frightened, starting with an intense sound can reinforce the fear instead of reducing it.

THE BETTER PATH

So What Should a Proper Gun Introduction Look Like?

The exact progression will vary from dog to dog, but the basic idea is simple.

1 Start With Something Positive

Birds · Retrieving · Play · Food · Movement

2 Introduce Sound at a Low Level

With live gunfire, begin at a distance where the shot is barely noticeable. With recorded sound, begin at a comfortable level.

3 Watch the Dog

The dog should continue acting normally.

4 Progress Gradually

Move closer or increase the sound only if the dog remains happy and confident.

5 Back Up When the Dog Tells You To

If the dog's demeanor changes, return to the previous comfortable level. There is no reason to force the process.

What If Your Dog Is Already Gun Shy?

If you are reading this because you think you already moved too quickly, stop testing the dog with more gunfire.

That does not mean the dog is automatically ruined.

I've worked with dogs that had very good hunting ability but shut down once gunfire was introduced.

Some of those dogs can make very good progress.

I do not guarantee that every gun-shy dog can be completely fixed.

Some cases take a month. Some take several months. Some require professional field work.

But the first step is usually the same:

THE FIRST STEP

Stop reinforcing the negative experience and start rebuilding confidence gradually.

AT HOME

Why I Created Gunshy Fix

I created Gunshy Fix because I kept seeing the same problem.

Owners had good dogs that could hunt, retrieve, and work birds—but once the gun came out, the dog shut down.

Some people did not have access to birds.

Some did not have enough property to safely start gunfire at a long distance.

Some did not have another person available to operate the gun while they worked the dog.

And some dogs reached a point in live training where they simply could not get past the sound of the gun getting closer.

Gunshy Fix gives owners a way to begin that process at home.

The program starts with calming music and progressively introduces gunfire recordings through the lessons.

The dog stays on each lesson until its demeanor remains normal.

If the dog shows concern, you go back.

The dog sets the pace.

The One Thing I Want You to Remember

Whether you are introducing gunfire to a puppy or working with a dog that has already had a bad experience:

TYCE'S RULE

Do not rush the gun.

Build something positive first.

Start quietly or far away.

Watch the dog's demeanor.

And move forward only when the dog is ready.

A slower introduction now can save you from spending months trying to repair a problem later.

Is Your Dog Already Showing Concern Around Gunfire?

Gunshy Fix was created as a controlled way to introduce or reintroduce gunfire sounds at home before transitioning to live field work.

LEARN HOW GUNSHY FIX WORKS